

A Philosophical Treatise on Human Intelligence Operations

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Introduction

This paper examines human intelligence (HUMINT) operations conducted by national intelligence communities from a United States (US)-centered perspective. Our research method involves conducting a literature review that draws insights from official government documents, legislation, academic research papers, and serious novels. This paper was originally titled "On the Acquisition and Use of Intelligence Agents" and had a respective thesis to describe methods for how agents might be recruited for operations on behalf of the US national intelligence community and to describe how information might be extracted from such agents. The first half of this paper is a response to this original thesis. On further reflection, we found that there existed great labyrinths surrounding interpretations for technical terms used within HUMINT operations. Thus, the second half of this paper is dedicated to a thesis which creates a philosophical treatise on the right way to think about HUMINT operations.

On the Acquisition and Use of Intelligence Agents

Contrary to popular belief, an agent is not an intelligence officer, but is more often a foreign national tasked to collect intelligence on behalf of a handler (Bellamy 2018, 23). Very rarely do intelligence officers act as James Bonds and collect HUMINT directly themselves (23). An intelligence officer (investigator, handler, recruiter, case officer, operations officer) either recruits or acts as an agent themselves and retrieves foreign intelligence either directly from a source or indirectly by extracting information from an agent who in turn extracts information from a primary source, unless the agent themselves is a primary source (Johnson 2010). The Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) leads HUMINT missions (Johnson 2010) and coordinates with other executive agencies like the Department of Defense's (DoD) HUMINT elements under the umbrella of the CIA's Directorate of Operations (CIA.gov 2024).

Common household terms analogous to agents are double agents, spies, rats, moles or informants, but not detainees. A handler might control an agent's means to money, sex or love, or drugs in exchange for sensitive information (secrets) (GNS&IGH 2011, 282). A handler might also try to recruit a person as an agent by bribing that person with money, flattery, and green cards (Johnson 2010, 326). Handlers might study social engineering and psychological techniques effective for fitting into local environments or torture methods historically used by the CIA. The location of an agent is typically a critical detail. Recruiters may hover around tourist spots, train stations (Warnes 2016), or operate within embassies by dealing with "walk-ins" (Johnson 2010). Cross-referencing HUMINT information solidifies an agent's worth.

GNS&IGH (2011) writes "the safest way to steal anything is to recruit someone who can steal it for you and who never knows your true identity" (281). GNS&IGH's (2011) quote is interesting because it reads like a well-tested trade secret in the art of recruiting agents. GNS&IGH (2011) even provides step-by-step instructions on the recruiting process (281). Tips for recruiters like being "honest and sincere friends" and to be able to "tell believable lies" (282) read like gems on the topic of recruiting agents. Furthermore, GNS&IGH (2011) describes how recruiters need just money, drugs, and sex or love to recruit almost anybody (282). The authors even break down the recruiting process into phases with subdivision steps (282). There is even

an acronym for the motives that sketch the psychological makeup of a motivated agent: MICE (money, ideology, compromise, and ego) (284).

Countries like Russia or China might attempt to obtain HUMINT by sending attractive female spies into bars (Johnson 2010, 311) or by hosting drinking parties where targeted scientists are invited and enticed into leaking secrets and technological trends (Pike 1997). More recent case studies for recruiting agents by the US might include bribing Afghanistan locals into providing HUMINT to aid military operations like Enduring Freedom (Grau 2004, 49).

CIA.gov (n.d.) importantly highlights the inadequacies of HUMINT collected by Iraq on Iranian nationals that made it difficult for the US to say without a doubt that Iran had obtained nuclear weapons during that time. This caveat highlights the need to “trust but verify” the HUMINT that is obtained from agents. Agent Rafid ‘Curve ball’ Ahmed Alwan passed faulty HUMINT to German intelligence officials, which was then subsequently passed to CIA officials, which led to the US falsely accusing Iraq of possessing weapons of mass destruction (Johnson 2010, 326). While HUMINT assets can be misleading, case studies like agent Oleg Penkosky can exalt the worth of HUMINT (326).

Japan's National Police Agency recruits defecting North Koreans to gather HUMINT for Japan but the specifics of that process is unknown (GNS&IGH 2011, 120). Recruiters often study the psychological makeup or profile of what makes a good agent. For example, employees that might feel condescended or have not received proper promotion rates (282), pay, or have not obtained the desired respect within an organization are more prone to being recruited as agents. Furthermore, those who are no longer ideologically aligned with their organization or home country, feel betrayed, feel angry, or are refugees or war criminals are often better recruits (296).

Wise's (2011) book *Tiger Trap* discusses how the People's Republic of China's (China) Second Bureau of the Ministry of State Security manages their spy assets and how their recruiters often use commercial, diplomatic, or journalistic covers (16). The story of Katrina Leung being "caught on tape reporting Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) secrets to Mao" (108) is also interesting as it showcases how China's agents can infiltrate the highest political echelons of the US government and intelligence communities by merely weaponizing sex and taking advantage of natural human instincts and desires. Sex is a legitimate weapon for intelligence officers where sex can be used in a variety of ways to convert someone into an agent by compromising, coercing, and blackmailing them (GNS&IGH 2011, 284; Johnson 2010, 313). For example, undercover China agent Katrina Leung and FBI officer J.J. Smith had sexual affairs where Smith would often be very comfortable with Leung so as to leave Smith's briefcase open near Leung which contained classified 'top secret' documents (Wise 2011, 163).

One interesting section of Wise's (2011) *Tiger Trap* is the explanation of how executive orders are not laws and that classification systems only apply to executive federal employees, which is one reason Katrina Leung was not charged with espionage as it was difficult to prove the "relating to national defense" clause under the provisions within the 1917 Espionage Act (175). Wise (2011) even writes "contrary to public perception, there is no crime of 'espionage' in US law" (209) which is fascinating if one is trying to persuade a potential agent that a collection

job is not dangerous. China, and to some extent Russia, have penetrated the CIA and FBI for extensive periods of time (247) without detection or punishment, making their tactics great case studies when learning about the most effective ways to recruit agents.

Johnson (2010) writes that, regarding the recruitment of agents, a CIA operations officer may offer to pay an agent to write an academic-like research paper about a topic (313). After a while, more money is paid for more sensitive ‘research’ reports, where “the tacit possibility of blackmail remains in the background, should the new recruit begin to have second thoughts” (313). It is difficult to know whether paying someone to write a ‘research’ paper is an ‘interrogation method’ or ‘interview.’

Detainees and Effective Control

Per §1045 (a)(2)(B)(i) of Public Law 114-92 (ODNI 2016, 571), the application of interrogation techniques that are outlined within US Army Field Manual 2-22.3 may be applied to the extraction of information from detainees in order to obtain foreign intelligence. It is important to highlight that detainees are not agents, even though HUMINT may be acquired by both sources. The possibility for detainees being converted into agents is an open question. The proper technical or legal term for extracting information from agents is an ‘interview,’ rather than an ‘interrogation,’ where ‘interrogation’ is instead paired with detainees (Duane 2012).

A naive scholar might wrongly interpret the legal wording of “under effective control” mentioned within several US government documents (ODNI 2016, 561; Hicks 2022; DoD 2012) to include social and psychological control like being under the allure of money, sex, or drugs (GNS&IGH 2011, 282) offered by an officer to a HUMINT source. For example, it is a mistake to think that one may apply the best practices of interrogation (FBI 2016) to any person suspected to possess valuable personal or secret information deemed relevant to national security that is not deemed to be a detainee. The techniques outlined within FBI (2016) are mostly restricted to detainees, not agents, depending on what interpretations are made by the Attorney General (Gerstein 2009).

A naive scholar might wonder whether the legal wording of "under the effective control" mentioned within §1045 (a)(2)(B)(i) of Public Law 114-92 titled "Limitations On Interrogation Techniques" (ODNI 2016, 561) could be legally interpreted as a 'detainment' in scenarios where an agent is psychologically dependent on a recruiter (i.e. under their effective control) or on what the recruiter provides, like providing or controlling an agent's means to sex, money, or drugs. The consequences of interpreting "effective control" as to allow 'psychological control of a detainee' means recruiters might treat and control agents as if those agents were psychological detainees. This stretched interpretation from "Limitations On Interrogation Techniques" might allow recruiters to control agents from great distances, but also creates conflicting legal interpretations of that collector's protected status.

Per DoD Directive 2310.01E titled “DoD Detainee Program,” a ‘detainee’ is defined as "any individual captured by, or transferred to, the custody or control of DoD personnel pursuant to the law of war" (Hicks 2022, 16). Analyzing this definition is important as it highlights how vague the terms like ‘control’ are under closer scrutiny. For example, an agent being

blackmailed into providing HUMINT might be considered to be ‘controlled’ and thus be categorized as a ‘detainee’ in addition to or instead of an ‘agent.’ Does the moment a detainee begins providing HUMINT convert that person’s protected legal status to an agent? The difference in categorizing the collector could be a matter of whether that person may be subjected to torture or not. The DoD has a rich history of committing war crimes by twisting definitions to meet operational requirements like deeming military-age males within areas of operations like Iraq to be considered armed combatants subjected to legally authorized assault by US military personnel (Assange 2015, 88-89).

Common sense suggests that the term ‘detainee’ may imply someone in handcuffs surrounded by or locally surveilled by law enforcement or investigative officials. “DoD Detainee Program” (Hicks 2022) and “Limitations On Interrogation Techniques” (ODNI 2016, 561) both reference the phrase “control” and “effective control,” but the terms remain quite vague. “DoD Intelligence Interrogations, Detainee Debriefings, and Tactical Questioning” (DoD 2012), on the other hand, references “effective control” many times including provisions limiting the areas of control described by the quote “conducted at a theater-level detention facility or at any other location to the extent required by law or DoD policy” (11) where “other location to the extent required by law” could simply be anywhere an agent or detainee wishes to go as long as they report back in for interrogation or interview sessions and are deemed critical to national security, which justifies the wording “by law” (11).

To what extent might “effective control” hold up within courts of law? Is “effective control” limited to physical shackles or could “effective control” include psychological shackles? Does a detainee or agent have to be held at Guantanamo Bay or could the detainee or agent be “effectively controlled” from great distances away from their handlers using techniques outlined within GNS&IGH (2011), FBI (2016), Johnson (2010), and US Army Field Manual 2-22.3? For the purposes of this paper, we presume “effective control” references physical control of a person, thus, we will not consider ‘detainees’ to be ‘agents’ or reference detainees to be sources of HUMINT. We also refer to criminals who choose to aid law enforcement investigations by spying on fellow gang members while wearing a wire in order to obtain some deal like a reduced sentence as ‘informants.’ Interestingly, “Torture is...prohibited by international law, but psychological coercion is not” (GNS&IGH 2011, 285), where torture is typically considered an ‘interrogation’ (Duane 2012).

The classification of a method as an ‘interrogation’ or ‘interview’ has different legal ramifications (Duane 2012). FBI (2016) describes interrogation methods that involve creating a personal brand for the handler that aligns with the target’s psychological tendencies, offers instructions on how to create more natural sounding conversations where the target feels comfortable sharing information, and offers instructions for engaging in a dialogue that is ideal for sharing details like asking targets to “describe something about the topic [followed by] more open probes” (4). Per Gerstein (2009), Obama introduced legal provisions requiring the CIA to follow the US Army Field Manual 2-22.3, which explains how to properly interrogate detainees. Yet, Gerstein (2009) points out that loopholes exist where the Attorney General may let the CIA create its own guidelines or interpretations. Thus, this paragraph highlights a spooky gray area for HUMINT operations as the Attorney General holds great interpretative power.

This gray area makes it difficult to separate ‘agents’ from ‘detainees’ as separate entities each deserving different techniques to obtain foreign intelligence. For agents, is blackmail really a legitimate method and why would it not be considered unethical psychological control? For informants, is it ethical to use the informant’s freedom as currency to obtain intelligence on insider threats (i.e. counterintelligence or domestic criminal investigations) by tasking them to spy on the criminal organizations they might be a member of? There is clearly a need for an official US document that clearly differentiates agents, detainees, and informants from each other as well as to clarify their respective methods of information extraction like interrogations, interviews, and psychological coercion. There exists too great a potential for arbitrary legal and ethical interpretations regarding HUMINT operations, which means a great risk of unjustified harm to individuals. The worries surrounding ambiguities for HUMINT operations should be addressed before any more study on the acquisition and use of HUMINT agents is conducted.

A Philosophical Treatise on Human Intelligence Operations

We draw inspiration and borrow methods from the preface of Plato’s (1998) *Cratylus* to offer a novel analysis on the way foreign and domestic HUMINT might be extracted from sources. We hope Plato (1998) will help us sort out terms which are sometimes synonymous, other times not, like agent, mole, double agent, spy, rat, detainee, and informant. The goal is to offer policymakers like the congressional oversight committees on intelligence a clearer path towards differentiating the terms used within HUMINT operations in order to better hold intelligence communities accountable and to better protect human rights.

Hermogenes, a character in *Cratylus*, early on views names (terms) as having the function of contentless tags (Plato 1998, xiii). Later on, Hermogenes adopts a new view of names to include fitting and sameness principles (xl). In contrast, the character Cratylus views names as having to be members of a set with an agreed upon consensus to presume that a certain amount of content or meaning is assigned to those names. For example, when we are naming potential sources of HUMINT, then ‘human’ would be one obvious associated name. By consequence, this consensus would require that any source of HUMINT cannot be directly obtained from nonhumans.

Thus, one can create a sort of logical calculus where ‘agents’ are presumed to be those HUMINT sources that are particularly responsible for collecting foreign intelligence (Johnson 2010, 309). This calculus quickly breaks down as ‘informant’ is more vague and may include either foreign or domestic HUMINT sources. Likewise, ‘spy’ is a more general term and might include friendly or hostile HUMINT sources. Legal legislations like the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act of 1978 usefully specifies “agents of a foreign power” (ODNI 2016, 418) in order to further the Venn diagrams of categorical names by declaring this particular type of agent to not be under US control. This calculus further complicates when ‘double agents’ are considered to be “agents of a foreign power” who are more aligned with friendly parties. “Agents of a foreign power” could also include anyone engaging in the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction (418).

Another complication is that some view the act of covertly placing listening devices within adversarial areas of operations by undercover intelligence officers or agents to be a

HUMINT operation (Johnson 2010, 309). The listening devices are technical intelligence but are worthless without an infiltrator having placed the devices in the right spots in the first place. Another complication is that terms may have a flux or change their meaning over time via changes in culture, language, or professional practice. For example, a ‘detainee’ might later be converted into an ‘informant,’ but an ‘informant’ is different from a ‘double agent’ since the informant’s role within their affiliated hostile organization may not have originally been to gather HUMINT. The difference lies in the fact that ‘double agents’ have professional training in intelligence collection while ‘informants’ might not have such training. A ‘detainee’ might become an ‘informant’ so that the informant can obtain a reduced judicial sentence by aiding law enforcement investigators in agreeing to spy on a gang or terrorist organization. The informant must still be affiliated with that gang or terrorist organization and the informant’s arrest must not be publicly available information so that the act of wearing a wire within areas of hostile operations or when the information is within close proximity to high value targets does not become a compromised investigative mission.

The constant flux or dynamic interpretations of terms for sources of HUMINT or the sudden complex of definitions that intelligence professionals find themselves having to navigate leads to an increased usage of more general terms like ‘spy’ or ‘rat’ or ‘snitch.’ The difficulty arises when determining whether the use of a source and those methods to coerce that source in order to obtain intelligence lies within the boundaries of ethical norms and legal provisions. For example, law enforcement officials are greatly limited in whether an interaction is deemed an ‘interrogation’ or ‘interview’ (Duane 2012). Likewise, the CIA and other elements of US intelligence communities are required by Obama’s Executive Order 13491 to align interrogation methods with provisions described within US Army Field Manual 2-22.3 (Gerstein 2009). Yet, interpretive loopholes might exist that allow the CIA to set their own guidelines on interrogation techniques with the Attorney General’s permission (Gerstein 2009). So no matter how clearly terms might be differentiated, at the end of the day, government officials could simply interpret anything to be anything, thus bypassing those cherished democratic ideas like rationality, justice, ethics, oversight, and accountability. If an intelligence operation is classified, then there is a chance that no abuses by government officials would be caught and corrected.

The legal phrase “effective control” in the context of regulating the treatment of detainees likely refers to subjects who are under physical constraints. Yet, coercive methods like blackmail or offering reduced sentences for cooperation suggest a psychological element of “effective control” in the context of recruiting agents or informants. Coupled with controlling a subject’s access to money, sex, or drugs, the ethical norms surrounding psychological effective control should be clarified. Government officials should adopt new and more specific terminology like ‘effective physical control’ and ‘effective psychological control’ to better protect human rights and to minimize vague or arbitrary interpretations of US law.

The point of being specific in naming sources of HUMINT and those respective methods of information extraction is to inform consumers on what HUMINT can be delivered and to clearly communicate inadequacies found within stated intelligence requirements. It is precisely the interaction between common terms and a consensus of ethical norms or laws that Socrates would deem as a crucial investigation needing to be carried out in order to correctly use such terms or names (Plato 1998, xx). Slang words like ‘spies’ or ‘rats’ might refer to more

specific terms, given the context in which the slang is used (i.e. gang members may prefer the aesthetics of the term ‘rats/snitches’ when describing ‘agents of [analogous] foreign powers’ (i.e. non-gang members) who have infiltrated their organizations).

Intelligence officers may pick and choose terms in a way that allows for narrow (i.e. literal) or loose (i.e. vague) interpretations of ethical norms and laws as these officers deem crucial in carrying out their duties like protecting national security and interests. One role of congressional oversight committees might be to create a check on the power vested in those members of intelligence communities and check the choices of those member’s regarding interpretations of laws and in choosing what terminology to use in order to protect national security and interests. For example, given the existence of virtual private networks, the National Security Agency (NSA) might deem all internet users as potential “agents of a foreign power” and therefore might justify mass surveillance of all internet traffic (Fortmeyer 2017, 31-32). Oversight committees could respond by restraining NSA activities when discovering that the NSA’s choice of interpretations or terminology was originally malicious or disingenuous. Intelligence officers act as narrative framers who manipulate terms to allow information to be extracted from sources. In sum, professional intelligence officers focus on set theory and in interpreting what is allowed or what might be appropriate human intelligence practices, given some consensus on ethical norms, laws, and clear and reasonable interpretations of terminology. The most competent but malicious intelligence officers likely create their own terminology with little to no connection with ethical norms or laws.

In Platonic fashion, this paper may pave the path towards an ideal form for describing what is a HUMINT source and what methods handlers may use on those sources. In *Cratylus*, Socrates suggests that Hermogenes learns the ideal form of a being (i.e. in our case, a human collector of information from other human sources) or the ideal action (i.e. the intellectual or physical labor like using an interrogative method of questioning or deploying a listening device) from poets like Homer (Plato 1998), who “distinguishes between the names humans call things and those the gods call them” (xxiv). Plato’s (1998) idea is that the naturally correct names that the gods use for concepts like ‘being’ or ‘action’ is too complex for mortal understanding, which is why more general terms like ‘spies’ or ‘rats’ or ‘questioning’ are useful generalizations for more specific terms like ‘agents’ or ‘interrogation.’ Thus, interpreting “effective control” to include psychological coercion can be reconciled or avoided by describing the practice with more generalized, but specific, terms like ‘HUMINT tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTP).’

One great analogy is the Greek tragic character Orestes whose “brutal, savage, and rugged nature” best matches his name ‘Orestes’ (Plato 1998, xxv). Thus, US Army Field Manual 2-22.3 “Human Intelligence Collector Operations” is a good name but is confusing for scholars by including a description for how to extract information from ‘detainees,’ where ‘detainees’ is not usually what comes to mind with what traditional HUMINT TTPs involve since ‘detainees’ are usually under physical “effective control” and are thus unable to go acquire secrets from sensitive adversarial areas of operations like closed-door conference rooms involving heads of states discussing their national security strategies.

Making a distinction between compelling someone to provide HUMINT (i.e. effective psychological control) and coercing them in order to extract HUMINT (i.e. effective physical

control) is necessary. Plato (1998) discusses desire as being a more powerful shackle than force (35), to which GNS&IGH (2011, 284) concurs, thus psychological control by binding one with desires may be the optimal HUMINT TTP. Psychological control of an agent is obtained through blackmail, offering reduced sentences, or controlling an agent's means to sex, drugs, and money. An agent under great psychological control will see little alternatives but to continue to collect HUMINT for intelligence officers. Plato (1998) says the greatest desire is the desire to be around great people (36), which suggests handlers might pose as academics with high status, or create a persuasive personal brand (FBI 2016), where handlers might only associate with an agent for as long as the agent produces "research papers" that provide sensitive state secrets, where the agent becomes convinced their espionage is making them a better person. The greater a handler creates a perception of high status or a persuasive personal brand, the more attractive an agent views the handler and the more willing the agent will spy for the handler, since the agent is psychologically manipulated, addicted, and controlled to do anything to remain in contact or association with the handler. A good handler might even exacerbate grievances an agent might hold, like providing reasons for why an agent did not get promoted.

The character Cratylus in *Cratylus* (Plato 1998) finds his way towards agreeing with the claim that names imitate things. If this claim is true, why do some call HUMINT collectors 'rats?' What in the nature of rats do HUMINT collectors share? Typically 'rats' is a derogatory term used only by those who are the victims of adversarial infiltration. The group of mammals called 'rats' is often associated with death as infestations of rats accompany the massive death tolls caused by plagues or rats help propagate the diseases themselves. In this case, the association of death brought by invoking 'rats' may be analogous to the death of successful political operations, based upon the presumption, which may not be true, that adversaries who obtain sensitive secrets will inevitably exploit that knowledge for political gain to the detriment of the victims of the spy who passed their secrets to enemies. In other words, allowing HUMINT 'rats' to run free and undetected creates heightened feelings of fear rooted in political realism. The political realism that argues that the act of having secrets or compartmentalizing information results in gains in tactical or strategic advantages for a nation state may be true or false. Those who believe in the validity of this ancient political realism may be more receptive to counterintelligence practices that eradicate HUMINT 'rats' from friendly areas of operations. Allowing HUMINT 'rats' to coexist among the more legitimate members of an organization is associated with the idea of a greatly weakened nation state or organization.

"To name something correctly, one must divide its nature [or essence]" (Plato 1998, xlv), and that essence is obtained by providing a description of the terminology used. Furthermore, intelligence professionals must construct names and assign names appropriately (xlvi). Calling insider threats 'rats' may not be appropriate if the intelligence community openly reveals its operations and holds no secrets. While spies might share sensitive information with enemies, friends can patch vulnerabilities before adversaries can exploit known vulnerabilities.

It is striking that Socrates, in the mouth of Plato (1998) in *Cratylus*, breaks down the essence of hero (hêrôs) to be a modification of love (erôs), where love is "the very thing from which the heroes sprang" (27). A connection one might draw here is that handlers are

dialecticians (rhêtores) who are essentially skilled questioners (erôtan) (27). The consequence that “heroes turn out to be speech-makers and questioners “ (28) validates the emphasis we place on handlers to be skilled at wordplay in order to be authorized to practice HUMINT TTPs. Furthermore, the best HUMINT heroes are sophists (28), which validates the title of this paper.

Closing Thoughts

While rejected by Bereczkei (2018), the Machiavellian Brain Hypothesis was founded by McGrew *et al.* (1999) and Humphrey (1976) and is summarized by Anderson (n.d.) as “we evolved high intelligence not to make better tools, but to use other monkeys better as tools: primates who were better at deception, or at detecting deception in others, left more descendants.” While a direct connection between the Machiavellian Brain Hypothesis and HUMINT collection operations might not be totally clear, a connection between the two seems plausible. Ties between the biological evolution of primates, intelligence, and tools to the disciplinary evolution of intelligence practices involving handlers, agents, deception, lies, and legal, ethical, or cultural interpretations should be studied more.

GNS&IGH (2011) highlighted that handlers greatly rely on deception as a means for control (282), while Johnson (2010) highlighted that agents can be unethical liars who can still help improve national security (326). An intelligence officer clearly spends large amounts of time studying terminology, status, appearance, self-reflection, self-awareness, narratives, manipulation, social engineering, questioning, communication, laws, ethics, psychology, addiction, dependencies, motives, and deception to better collect HUMINT. The extent to which a handler must dehumanize an agent (Bellamy 2018, 15) in order to extract information should involve a dialogue between congressional oversight committees on intelligence, the Attorney General, and the leadership of executive branches of government to keep the practices of HUMINT operations ethical, reasonable, legal, and necessary to ensure national security.

Plato (1998) warned of the dangers of self-deception, where one might presume Plato would suggest handlers be self-conscious and reflective, while also being wise enough to use words in a way as to be instructive (87) and not confusing, depending on what a situation requires. FBI (2016) supported the idea of raising awareness of one’s own thoughts and appearance when interacting with an agent by being in the presence of a colleague whose sole job is to observe their partner to ensure their partner does not deviate from the established brand tailored to the agent’s profile that was deemed most likely to be effective in controlling the agent.

While terminology may be useful in determining who can provide intelligence and how those providers might be treated, the narratives invented or warped by intelligence officers are inseparable from the study of the relevant terminology and its effectiveness (Coogan *et al.* 2018, 3). The biblical act of mankind naming animals, displaying their dominion over them, may be analogous to the power gained by handlers in naming varying types of HUMINT sources and methods (80). The capability to deceive is imbedded within all cultures, from the West’s stories of Odysseus, Jacob and Rebekah, and Native American traditions (9) to the East’s stories of Sun Wukong, Kitsune, Nezha, and Tenali Ramakrishna (ChatGPT-4o 2024).

Conclusion

Our thesis was to describe methods for how agents might be recruited for operations on behalf of the US national intelligence community, to describe how information might be extracted from such agents, and to create a philosophical treatise on the right way to think about HUMINT operations. Having done so, we may now benefit from a grander perspective on HUMINT operations.

We hope this paper was valuable for readers by delivering a somewhat first principles account of HUMINT operations. We suspect the ambiguities surrounding the relevant terminology might not necessarily be errors but could rather be intentional trade practices deemed necessary to achieve desired outcomes by HUMINT efforts. Intelligence officers have a duty to deceive the media, the public, congress, and agents, while scholars and congressional oversight committees have a duty to reveal the truth and protect human rights, respectively.

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